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DJIA 41953.32 ▼ 11.31 0.03% NASDAQ 17691.63 ▼ 0.3% STOXX 600 552.98 ▼ 0.4% 10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 6/32, yield 4.233% OIL \$68.26 ▲ \$1.10 GOLD \$3,040.00 ▲ \$4.10 EURO \$1.0854 YEN 148.78

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **SoftBank signed** a deal to buy U.S.-based chip designer Ampere for \$6.5 billion, the Japanese company's latest investment to advance its artificial-intelligence initiatives. **B4**

◆ **Early U.S. stock gains** faltered and reversed, leaving the S&P 500 and Nasdaq down 0.2% and 0.3%, respectively, at the close. The Dow fell less than 0.1%. **B9**

◆ **Several leveraged ETFs** have seen most of their value erased in a matter of weeks after the funds last year emerged as a go-to investment for short-term traders. **B1**

◆ **The economic outlook** weakened for a third-straight month in February, enervated by faltering consumer confidence. **A2**

◆ **The family of a whistleblower** who took his own life filed a wrongful-death lawsuit against Boeing, accusing it of harassing and intimidating the former quality manager after he complained of safety lapses. **B1**

◆ **Nike posted lower profit** and sales for its latest quarter, as the company stepped up discounts to clear inventory in the early days of a turnaround. **B3**

◆ **CK Hutchison in its earnings** report flagged supply-chain and geopolitical risks ahead, though it didn't address Beijing's scrutiny of its Panama ports deal. **B2**

◆ **Darden recorded** higher sales and earnings in the winter quarter as it expanded its footprint and attracted cost-conscious diners. **B3**

◆ **PDD reported** slower quarterly profit and revenue growth, capping a turbulent year for the owner of the Temu bargain app. **B4**

World-Wide

◆ **Trump signed** a much-anticipated executive order directing Education Secretary Linda McMahon to dismantle the Education Department, escalating a bitter political fight over the future of the agency. **A1**

◆ **Elon Musk is set** to receive a briefing on the U.S. military's top-secret war plans for China, according to two U.S. officials, giving the wealthy businessman and presidential adviser insight into one of the Pentagon's most closely guarded operational blueprints. **A3**

◆ **The Taliban released** American George Glezmann, ending his two-year detention and giving Trump a diplomatic victory that could reshape U.S. relations with Afghanistan. **A7**

◆ **A judge temporarily** blocked members of Musk's DOGE from Social Security Administration systems containing personal information, saying their work was likely an illegal "fishing expedition." **A5**

◆ **Trump rescinded** an order targeting Paul Weiss, as the law firm bent to White House pressure and agreed to a series of concessions to avoid a client exodus. **A4**

◆ **Netanyahu fired** his domestic spy chief, extending a purge of rivals in Israel's security establishment while further overhauling the cabinet that presided during the Oct. 7, 2023, attacks. **A7**

◆ **Four Canadian nationals** were executed in China on drug-related charges, Canadian authorities said, in a rare case of China carrying out the death penalty against Westerners. **A16**

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Celebrants Trumpet the Arrival of Spring



WINTER'S END: A member of the Druid Order blows a horn for a celebration at Tower Hill in London on Thursday. The vernal equinox marks the start of the spring season for the Northern Hemisphere and fall in the Southern Hemisphere.

Fossil-Fuel Industry Exacts Its Revenge on Green Activists

Environmentalists reel under Trump's pro-fossil fuel and anticlimate actions

By **BENOÎT MORENNE**

The oil-and-gas industry is landing blow after blow against climate activists.

The Trump administration has cranked out approvals of major projects to ship liquefied natural gas from the Gulf Coast and killed a host of climate-related initiatives. Meanwhile, Texas billionaire Kelcy Warren has won a nearly \$700

million verdict against Greenpeace that could spell the end of the group's U.S. presence.

These are major setbacks for green groups. They have opposed new exports of U.S. natural gas, sought to stop new pipelines and asked the government to step up support of communities affected by climate change. The defeats herald the challenges that activists face as President Trump and his allies move to expand fossil fuels' footprint here and abroad.

Trump, a Republican, has directed federal agencies to speed up permits for oil-and-gas infrastructure, a key de-

mand of his oil-and-gas donors—including Warren, co-founder of pipeline giant Energy Transfer. The Trump team also is making deep cuts at the Environmental Protection Agency, which played a central role in the Biden administration's rollout of climate policies.

Legal experts said that while green groups have dealt with previous administrations' attempts to weaken environmental standards, they are facing an extraordinary challenge under Trump 2.0.

"What we're seeing now is sort of this sense of the opportunity for revenge," said Josh

Galperin, an associate professor of law at Pace University.

Oil-and-gas executives who have seen their projects challenged by environmentalists and mired in lengthy permitting have applauded Trump's actions.

"We've just kind of been the frog in the boiling pot, and it's just gotten worse, and worse, and worse," said Alan Armstrong, the chief executive of pipeline company Williams.

Green groups in recent years have become proficient at litigating against and protesting new pipelines, starting with Keystone XL.

They also have opposed

Trump Moves To Close Education Agency

Executive order seeks to shutter a department that Congress established

By **KEN THOMAS**
AND **MATT BARNUM**

WASHINGTON—President Trump signed a much-anticipated executive order directing Education Secretary Linda McMahon to dismantle the Education Department, escalating a bitter political fight over the future of the agency.

The order directs McMahon to facilitate the closure of the agency to the maximum extent possible and permitted by law. McMahon will face a number of complications in shuttering the department, a task she has called its "final mission."

Trump, a Republican, staged the signing ceremony from the East Room of the White House, where schoolchildren sat at desks and appeared to sign miniature versions of the order as the president signed the official document. He was joined by a group of Republican governors, including Govs. Greg Abbott of Texas and Ron DeSantis of Florida.

"It sounds strange doesn't it? Department of Education, we're going to eliminate it," Trump said, adding he hoped McMahon will be "our last secretary of Education."

The order followed an announcement from the department this month that it was slashing its staff by about half, cutting 1,950 staff positions in total, including 1,315 federal employees through a reduction-in-force process.

"See you in court," Randi Weingarten, president of the American Federation of Teachers, said Thursday. *Please turn to page A6*

Behind the Rapid-Fire Migrant Removals

The proclamation hit the White House website just before 4 p.m. Eastern Time Saturday: President Trump was invoking wartime powers to immediately deport alleged members of the Venezuelan gang Tren de Aragua. In less than four hours, three planes carrying more than 250 migrants were in the air.

By **Juan Forero** in Bogotá, Colombia,
and **Vera Bergengruen** in Washington

In an immigration detention facility in Texas that morning, many of the men knew they were about to be deported but thought they were headed home to Venezuela. Some told family members they were even happy that their ordeal in the U.S. appeared to be over.

"He was relieved because he was ready to leave the hole where he had been," Eirisneb Rodríguez said, recounting a call last Friday from her husband, Obed Navas, a barber who lived in Sherman, Texas.

The next night, the Venezuelans stepped off planes to learn they had landed in El Salvador. There, President Nayib Bukele's government met them with hundreds of soldiers and police to film their handover and lock them up in the Terrorism Confinement *Please turn to page A4*

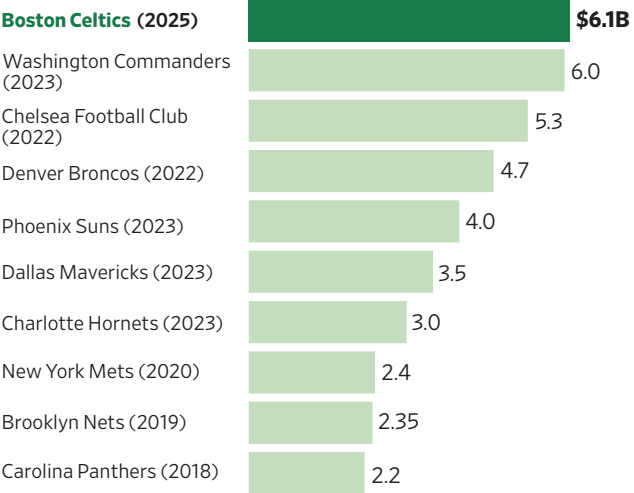
◆ **DOJ, court face off over deportations..... A4**

◆ **Visa holders, tourists get harsher welcome..... A5**

Celtics Sell for \$6.1 Billion

BIG GREEN: A deal to sell the Boston Celtics to private-equity firm managing partner William Chisholm sets a record for the highest price paid for a team in American sports history. **A12**

Global largest sales of sport franchises, in billions



Congrats, You're the Oldest Person in Town. Now Prove It.

Emerging focus on longevity puts age claims under new scrutiny; off by 30 years

By **AMY DOCKSER MARCUS**

Ben Meyers heard about a Japanese woman believed to be the world's oldest barber at 106. So he sent a colleague to her salon outside of Tokyo for a haircut.

He wanted to know if Shitsui Hakoishi's story checked out.

People who live beyond 100 are getting more attention than ever, with billionaires and entrepreneurs plowing money into longevity companies and scientists looking for treatments to slow aging. But the added scrutiny has revealed a challenge of studying

aging: It's really hard to prove someone is as old as they say.

For a range of reasons—from incorrect or missing records to early-life lies that stuck—the stated ages of the super-old often don't hold up to scrutiny.

For Meyers, a commercial insurance broker, verifying people's ages is a passion. It's also his

new gig. He co-founded a company called Longevityquest in 2022 focused on improving old-age verification. He and his team dig through old records, construct elaborate *Please turn to page A9*

Wife Fights to Free Prisoner of Russia

Thousands of Ukrainian civilians are behind bars, some enduring torture

By **IAN LOVETT**
AND **NIKITA NIKOLAIENKO**

Natalya Barchuk edged nervously toward the prison in the Russian-occupied city of Kalanchak in southern Ukraine clutching a parcel of food and a bag of clothes.

She'd been told her husband might be inside, one of thousands of civilians detained in an opaque prison system on occupied territory. Guards accepted the care packages but wouldn't tell her whether her Oleksiy was there.

Natalya, then 55, had traveled from her hometown in search of him and now found herself alone in an

alien place where Russian troops cruised the streets in armored vehicles and entered apartments at will. Once, she saw a Russian soldier batter an old woman with a rifle butt.

"I'm sitting in a hornet's nest," she wrote in a text message to a Wall Street Journal reporter.

At the jail days after her first visit, a guard handed her a bag. Ripping it open, she found a familiar blue T-shirt among other dirty clothes. She pressed it to her face and inhaled a recognizable scent. She began to sob. She had found him.

Now came the hardest *Please turn to page A9*

INSIDE



CHRIS WALTERS/WIREIMAGE/GETTY IMAGES

BUSINESS & FINANCE
Biggie Smalls's mother won fight for control of rapper's work just before her death. **B1**



MANSION
With a mix of tenacity and creative marketing, real-estate agents sell after disaster. **M1**